

CORE FORMULA

Feeling signal -> brief validation -> permission or bridge -> facts, details or next step. -> Feeling signal: name the emotional weight without overclaiming - "That sounds frustrating." -> Brief validation: show why it makes sense from their side - "I can see why it landed that way." -> Bridge: signal the turn - "The piece I want to check is..." (never "but" first). -> Facts: give the accurate information, correction or next step without erasing the emotion. -> Compact: "That sounds [feeling]. I want to acknowledge that first. The factual piece is [fact]."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Start with one short emotion-first sentence before any explanation: "That sounds really frustrating. The detail I want to check is..."

BEST FOR

- Venting, frustration, disappointment or embarrassment
- Customer complaints and painful feedback
- Conflict repair and overwhelmed team members
- Moments where a factual correction would otherwise sound dismissive
- Statements where impact is more urgent than sequence - "I felt ignored," "this is impossible," "that was humiliating"
- Acknowledging pressure before you discuss deadlines, policy, evidence or trade-offs

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · One-line minimum

- "That sounds really frustrating."
- "That sounds heavy."
- "That sounds rough."
- "That sounds like a lot."
- "I can see why that landed badly."
- "That is a lot to take in."
- "I hear you."
- "That sounds rough. The fact piece is..."

Everyday support · Meet the feeling first

- "That sounds really frustrating. What part of it hit hardest?"
- "That sounds heavy. Before we get into details, I want to acknowledge that."
- "That makes sense to feel upset about."
- "That sounds humiliating, and I want to stay with that first."
- "It makes sense that being called out publicly would hit hard."
- "The impact was real, even if the intent is unclear."
- "That sounds unfair from where you were standing. What part hit hardest?"

Work and pressure · Updates, meetings, team load

- "I can hear there is pressure around this. Let us name that first, then sort the timeline."
- "It makes sense that people are worried. I will speak to that first, then walk through the plan."
- "That result was disappointing. Let us name that first, then look at what the data tells us."
- "I hear the pressure. Let us acknowledge the load first, then sort what has to move."
- "I get why that would land badly. The factual piece I should add is..."

- "That is a poor experience to have. I will not minimise it. The next practical step is..."

Bridge to the facts · Clarify or correct without dismissing

- "The feeling makes sense from what you saw. The fact I need to correct is..."
- "I want to stay with the feeling and also get the facts right."
- "Can we separate the impact from the sequence for a moment?"
- "One detail that may change the picture is..."
- "The detail I want to check is..."
- "I can see why that felt alarming. The fact I need to correct is..."
- "I can see that landed badly. I want to address that before explaining my intent."

Recovery and re-sequencing · Back up when you rushed

- "I jumped to the facts too fast. Let me back up."
- "I may have named that wrong. What is the feeling closer to?"
- "That came out formulaic. What I mean is: I do care about how this affected you."
- "I do not want to make this worse. Let me slow down."
- "I am not saying every detail is settled. The feeling makes sense from how it looked to you."
- "Before I respond to the specific point, I want to acknowledge that this felt unfair to you."
- "I think we have named the impact. Would it help to move into the details now?"

Boundaries and safety · Pressure, limits, urgent moments

- "I can tell this matters. I am still not able to agree to that, but I want to respect the feeling behind it."
- "This is scary. I need two quick facts so we can handle it safely."
- "I hear the urgency. First: this is stressful. Second: here is what we know so far."
- "I can see that hurt. My intention does not cancel the impact, so I want to address that first."
- "That cost you time, and that is frustrating. I will check the process after acknowledging that."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "They completely ignored me" -> "No they did not; they were just busy."
Better: "That probably felt dismissive. They may also have been busy."
Best: "That probably felt dismissive - I want to stay with that first. Then we can check whether it was intentional or just timing."
- Weak: "This deadline is impossible" -> "It is not impossible; we just need to prioritise."
Better: "I can hear the pressure. Let us prioritise."
Best: "I can hear the pressure, and it makes sense this feels too much right now. Let us name the load first, then separate what must be done from what can move."
- Weak: "Your team wasted my time" -> "Actually, our records show we replied within policy."
Better: "I am sorry it felt like a waste of time. Our records show..."
Best: "That is a frustrating experience, and I would not want to feel bounced around either. I will address the impact first, then check the record so we solve it accurately."
- Weak: "You never listen" -> "That is not true. I listened yesterday."
Better: "It sounds like you felt unheard."
Best: "It sounds like you felt unheard, and I want to take that seriously before defending myself. Can I reflect what I am hearing, then talk about the specific moments?"

DECISION TREE

If Is there immediate danger or a time-critical decision?

Compress the acknowledgement, then give the facts needed for safety.

"This is scary. I need two quick facts so we can handle it safely."

If Is the person emotionally activated or using strong evaluative language?

Start with emotion before facts.

"That sounds really frustrating."

If Is the emotion clear enough to name?

Use a modest label; if not, use a broad impact phrase.

"That sounds like a lot."

If Do you need to correct or clarify facts?

Bridge after the acknowledgement; never lead the bridge with "but."

"The detail I want to check is..."

If Did they settle or confirm?

Move into facts, details or next steps.

"When you are ready, we can look at what happened next."

If Are you using emotion-first to avoid accountability?

Stop and take responsibility directly.

"You are right to be annoyed. That was my miss, and here is what I will do."

SCENARIOS

Someone vents about unfair treatment

Meet the emotional impact before testing accuracy. — "That sounds unfair from where you were standing. What part hit hardest?"

A team member is overwhelmed by workload

Name the pressure before prioritising. — "I hear the pressure. Let us acknowledge the load first, then sort what has to move."

You need to correct misinformation

Validate the feeling, then separate the fact. — "I can see why that felt alarming. The fact I need to correct is..."

You are receiving criticism

Acknowledge the impact before you explain your intent. — "I can see that landed badly. I want to address that before explaining my intent."

A client is angry about the process

Acknowledge the cost before the policy. — "That cost you time, and that is frustrating. I will check the process after acknowledging that."

Safety or urgent decision

Use a compressed emotion-first bridge, then the facts. — "This is scary. I need two quick facts so we can handle it safely."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Immediate safety facts are required
- The person explicitly asks for data or a decision first
- The emotion is unclear and a label would be presumptuous
- The conversation is being used to abuse, threaten or coerce
- Emotion-first wording would imply you agree with a harmful or inaccurate claim
- You would be using empathy to pressure someone toward agreement

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the load

In three real complaints today, silently name the emotion to yourself before you reply. Notice how often the urge to correct arrives first.

Day 2 — The three-second gate

Read a complaint sentence, pause for three seconds, and write one emotion-first opener under twelve words. It must contain no correction, advice or explanation.

Day 3 — Add the bridge

Take yesterday's openers and add a factual bridge that starts with "and" or "the detail I want to check is" - never with "but."

Day 4 — Correct without erasing

Pick five inaccurate but understandable claims. For each, validate the felt impact, then correct one fact in neutral wording that keeps feeling and fact separate.

Day 5 — Impact before intent

Write three defensive replies you would normally give. Rewrite each impact-first, adding one sentence of responsibility, with no "but" in the first sentence.

Day 6 — Say it live

In one real conversation, use emotion before facts once. Afterwards, ask the person whether it felt helpful, too much, or too slow.

Day 7 — Calibrate and repair

Practise shortening the move when someone asks for facts, and use one recovery line when you mis-sequence, so backing up feels natural under pressure.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I respond to the emotional weight before the facts?
- Did my first sentence avoid correction, advice or explanation?
- Did I keep facts and feelings separate, without treating either as fake?
- Did I avoid using "I understand, but" as a dismissal wrapper?
- Did I repair if I mislabelled the emotion or rushed?
- Did I return to the facts, decision or next step once the feeling was met?